



SELF-LOADING AND FULLY AUTOMATIC RIFLES

Machine-guns were well established by the early 20th century, but semiautomatic and automatic rifles were not as universally accepted. However, the outbreak of World War II in 1939 caused a profound change in firearms technology. Self-loading, or semiautomatic, military rifles (those firing one round at a time), which had been treated with some caution by military authorities, were now rapidly accepted for general use. The speed with which this took place is clearly demonstrated by the development of what was to become the M1 Carbine in only 13 days. Equal attention was paid to the design of fully automatic rifles, capable of discharging multiple rounds continuously while the trigger was kept pulled. By 1943, nearly every nation involved in the conflict had either adopted or tested automatic rifles and used them on the battlefield to devastating effect.

▼ STURMGEWehr 44 WITH KRUMMLAUF DEVICE

Date 1944

Origin Germany

Barrel 16½in (41cm)

Caliber 7.62 × 33mm

The Sturmgewehr 44, or StG44 (see pp.176–77), was christened by Adolf Hitler and first issued to German troops in 1944. It was the first true assault rifle (see pp.244–45), capable of switching between semiautomatic and fully automatic modes. It was first deployed on the Eastern Front to counter the Soviet infantry armed with the PPSH-41 (see pp.208–09). Some examples of this weapon were equipped with curved barrels (the *Krummlauf* device) so that they could be fired indirectly at targets out of the user's direct line of sight by means of a prismatic sight. This device would prove especially useful in house-to-house fighting.

